



FAMILY COURT DATA REPORT · STATE SERIES · NO. 10

FLORIDA

WHAT FAMILIES ARE REPORTING.

Pulled from the Family Rights Registry — the first cross-state dataset on what pro se parents are actually experiencing inside Florida's family courts and child-welfare system.

116

FLORIDA FAMILIES ON RECORD · 124
CHILDREN IMPACTED · 21 MONTHS
MEDIAN MONTHS LOST OF PARENTING
TIME

REPORT GENERATED
APRIL 26, 2026

COUNTIES REPRESENTED
34 OF 67

COMPILED BY
MEG · STANDWITHMEG.COM

THE HEADLINE NUMBERS

FLORIDA AT A GLANCE.

Across 116 Florida families reporting through the Family Rights Registry, the patterns are consistent: long durations in court, serious financial loss, and a disproportionate number of parents going unrepresented because they ran out of money fighting.

CHILDREN IMPACTED 124 115 of 116 families reported child counts	MEDIAN ATTORNEY FEES \$16,500 per reporting family	MEDIAN MONTHS LOST 21 of parenting time	WENT PRO SE 56.0% 27.6% after running out of money
SUBMISSIONS 116	AVG CHILDREN / FAMILY 1.1	FAMILIES REPORTING CHILDREN 115 of 116	COUNTIES REPRESENTED 34

WHY THIS REPORT EXISTS.

On January 29, 2024, I lost custody of all five of my children.

- NO TRIAL.
- NO QUESTIONING.
- NO SUBSTANTIATED ABUSE.

It took only a signature on an ex parte emergency order to erase a mother. I refused to disappear. I fought back, and built the Family Rights Registry so Florida families — and families in every state — would stop being invisible to the data. This report is their record.

— MEG · [STANDWITHMEG.COM](https://standwithmeg.com)

02 THE COST OF FLORIDA FAMILY COURT

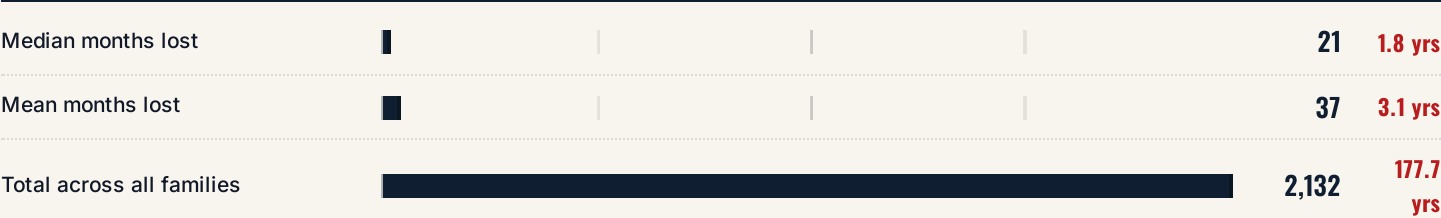
Legal fees are the largest reported expense, but they are not the only one. Lost wages, evaluation costs, and reunification services compound the financial loss — pushing most families toward pro se representation once their savings run out.

EXPENSE CATEGORY	RESPONSES	MEDIAN	MEAN	TOTAL REPORTED
Attorney Fees	70	\$16,500	\$54,362	\$3,805,370
Lost Wages	55	\$24,000	\$363,307	\$19,981,900
Other Court Fees	37	\$525	\$4,558	\$168,645
Therapy / Evaluations	54	\$2,000	\$9,394	\$507,270
Reunification Services	40	\$400	\$3,722	\$148,885
GAL Fees	42	\$750	\$17,618	\$739,965
Asset Loss ¹	51	\$50,000	—	—
Estimated Median Family Impact	—	\$94,175	—	—

Median vs. mean: Median is the middle reported amount, so it better reflects the typical reporting family when a few very large expenses appear. Mean is the average across reporting families and can be pulled higher by outliers.

1. On asset loss: One respondent reported an extreme outlier that skews the mean beyond usefulness. We report the median (\$50,000) and suppress the mean and total, pending data-quality review. Lost Wages also contains wide variance; median is the honest headline.

LOST PARENTING TIME · MONTHS



03 WHO IS REPORTING · FLORIDA

Most families documenting in Florida are currently active in, or recently closed out of, long-running cases. Nearly half have lost all contact with their children.

CASE STATUS · SYSTEM AFFECTED

CASE STATUS

Not provided		47	41%
Active case: stuck or delayed		43	37%
Case closed: within last 2 years		14	12%
Case closed: more than 2 years ago		10	9%
I am not currently in court but still affected		1	1%

SYSTEM AFFECTED

Both Family Court and CPS		45	39%
Unknown		30	26%
Family Court Only		25	22%
CPS (Child Protective Services) Only		15	13%

DURATION · CUSTODY OUTCOMES

TIME IN SYSTEM

1 – 3 years		25	22%
3 – 5 years		21	18%
5 – 10 years		17	15%
5+ years		14	12%
Less than 6 months		8	7%

CUSTODY STATUS

No Contact / Total Loss of Access		38	33%
50/50 Joint		20	17%
Visitation Only		16	14%
Adopted Out (Rights Terminated)		13	11%
Full Custody		11	9%

GEOGRAPHY · ALLEGATIONS REPORTED

TOP COUNTIES

Pinellas		6	5%
Polk		5	4%
Orange		4	3%
Okaloosa		3	3%
Brevard		3	3%
Escambia		3	3%

TOP ALLEGATIONS REPORTED

Family Court False Accusations (Domestic Violence/Abuse/Alienation)		23	20%
False Accusations CPS (Non-Medical) (Vengeful ex-partner, malicious report)		17	15%
Other: (Short answer)		15	13%
Family Court		14	12%
High Conflict Divorce		9	8%

05 PARENT VOICES — FLORIDA

Quotes appear as submitted. Long submissions are trimmed with [...] to fit the page; the full unedited quote is available in the online version of this report.



Ruined all of us I suffer from PTSD trauma, anxiety, torture, because I think about my daughters every day they're being well taken care of my family is extremely disappointed. My mother passed away, never met my daughters and her final words were for me to do whatever it takes [...]

— BRUNA

ON THE REPORTED ALLEGATIONS

This system didn't protect our family—it destroyed it. My brother's three children were taken in the middle of the night and split apart into different homes, stripping them not only from their father but from each other. Siblings who were raised together have been denied even [...]

— FLORIDA PARENT · DAVID

MORE VOICES FROM FLORIDA

Family court is a broken system, attorneys all say they same they want to help they care, bullshit they just want money. You can have proof but once your in the system there is no way of getting out. You are stuck spending money and have to sit and watch your children suffer. [...]

— VANESSA

Left me broken inside, being a mom is my greatest blessing and my kids were stolen from me without even asking me what happened or hearing me at all.

— CHASTITY

Traumatized my children (and the parents), caused punitive damages, emotional harm, financial issues, etc

— MELISSA

This has destroyed my children - A+ students down to Fs and suspensions from school, mental issues and suicidal thoughts, major health issues with their father denying anything being wrong with them, kids surviving regular abuse while their father hides behind "corporal [...]

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

05 PARENT VOICES, CONTINUED



Tore us apart and broke many bonds #KaynTay Pamela Bokhoven #KaynTay Shop and Outreach Campaign Manager, aoa-anc.org Justice and Accountability Act Committee written by Francesca Amato Francesca Amato 325-225-8050 Subject: Urgent Call for Family Justice and Accountability Reform [...]

— PAM

Systematic psychological abuse, financial abuse, civil rights violations, parental rights violations, FERPA violations

— DUSTIN

Family court consistently leaned into parental rights over children's rights leaving them 50% of the time with an unsafe documented abuser and alcoholic.

— SAMANTHA

The system destroys families creating trauma across multiple generations

— STEPHANIE

They destroyed my life and my family and my life

— STEPHANIE

Taken a retired female Air Force veteran to question how she could ever lay her life on the line for a corrupt judicial system .

— SACHEL

Because of this system I have no family, and my children are missing a vital part of theirs.

— DANIELLE

It has broken my trust in support for woman and children such as myself and my daughter, it has caused me severe depression, it has gotten me ill, caused strife in my family, has caused financial hardship and my daughter has been handed to an abuser to be traumatized and [...]

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

A controlling father and his family made multiple false claims with CPS until they found an investigator who falsified reports in order to remove the children.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

05 PARENT VOICES, CONTINUED



I already put before, but violated due process caused harm to the children, confusion, took time away made the children believe they were liars and confused them of what truth is and enabled financial and mental and emotional abuse of myself and the kids to continue and extreme [...]

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Harm, PTSD, damages, lost of all my kids young moment. Puberty, teen time completely loss.

— NYULKA

Split the family up adopted to strangers when siblings and other relatives were available to care for children

— BRENDA

The system has caused significant distress to our family, impacting our children and traumatizing my wife and me, as well as our five children. We are seeking justice and accountability for these actions.

— PAUL

Stolen parts of me that I'll ever get back. I'm mourning people that are still alive and I hold it together every day for the sake of myself and my other two kids

— BROOKE

When they walked into my life this last time I had Recently married my boyfriend from when I was 16 years old, we had three kids. We lived across the street from his parents. We had a new pick up truck . We needed help with housing upgrades and communication and some other [...]

— THYME

You took our children, so all we had was whole lot of time and pissed off. You had money, I had the truth, and it set my children free.

— CRYSTAL

My family was destroyed by family court and Dr. Deborah O. Day. We were a loving family and I was their mom! My daughters were removed from my care in a hearing that the 5th District Court of Appeals said that Judge Shawn L. Briese denied Mother's due process and the hearing to [...]

— LINDA MARIE

Shattered self and family. Human trafficking violations. Child abuse. The “justice” system is broken.

— TANYA

05 PARENT VOICES, CONTINUED



This system has allowed an abusive addict to destroy my children and my family and has allowed a former attorney without a bar card for drugs to have unfettered access to addict my children to drugs..

— STACI

Empowered the abuser, punished the abused.

— MELISSA

accusations of child abuse Cost me my living wage until the case was closed. This cost me Easter first holiday I've ever missed. This cost me my pride this cost me my college tuition yes I had to pay for Attorney fee and had no income due to false allegations until the case was [...]

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

While no actual time was lost with my child, as I CHOSE to enter a 2 year program, we have suffered severe mental, physical, emotional, and spiritual trauma do to the ignorance and lack of due diligence by my CPS investigator and team.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Broke me mentally emotionally, and financially also destroyed my three boys relationship with their mother and their outlook on what a happy healthy family should be.

— SHELLEY

False allegations had my kids taken away , myself oldest son and bf thrown in jail fighting for our life , crooked detective fabricated evidence Google me

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

This systematic dismantling of my life has functioned as a total institutional erasure, stripping away my motherhood, my professional identity, and my sanctuary all at once. It is the profound trauma of being forced to fight for my basic humanity against the very systems [...]

— CHRISTINA

It has made me completely irrelevant and my children have a constant feeling of being lost. Without a mother's love and guidance it's hard to be loved.

— MONA

Irreparable damage to my professional reputation and my child's reputation.

— KRISTIN

05 PARENT VOICES, CONTINUED



It has caused so much division and destruction and grief in mine and my children's lives... I spoke up for myself and them and they failed to protect us

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Destroyed my relationship with my children to the point my daughter states to DCF/Police “I love snuggling with daddy, but daddy is a bad man, he is mean to my mommy”...

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Violated and dismantled us. With no empathy, no regard for my children and their futures and no sense of morality, family court and DCF continue their heinous tirades on us and we are tired.

— AMY

The State of Florida has weaponized the dependency system to turn my children into federal revenue streams, using fabricated evidence to kidnap them and judicial misconduct to hold them hostage, effectively trafficking them through foster care to harvest Title IV-E bounties.

— PAUL

They have stole my entire world made my life unmanageable my babies need me they want me

— HEATHER

Trying make parents separate and division between extended family. Mother and son etc

— ANGELLA

Litigation abuse, torn my family apart, put my son in an extremely toxic environment !

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

The broken system has only shown me how much we can't trust anyone. Which is sad because those are the people who promised to uphold the law and they are far from it. My heart breaks every day. I can't sleep, I cry randomly, I can't put on any weight and keep it, I feel [...]

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Irreplaceable damages Motherhood, Childhood

— MELISSA

71 Florida parents submitted ranked quotes. 42 appear in this report; the remainder are available at standwithmeg.com/fl.

06 HOW TO READ THIS REPORT

WHAT THIS IS

The Family Rights Registry is a national, parent-reported data collection run by Stand With Meg. Every figure in this Florida report comes from Florida respondents who voluntarily submitted survey entries about their experience inside family court and/or CPS.

This report is built to help families, advocates, reporters, and legislators see the patterns emerging in Florida — not to replace formal research, and not to name individual judges or counties as responsible parties.

WHAT IT ISN'T

This is not a representative sample. Respondents self-select. The 116 Florida families reporting here are not the universe of Florida families in court — they are the families who found the survey, trusted it enough to submit, and told us what happened to them.

Financial figures are self-reported. We flag outliers and report medians when means are distorted (see page 3, note 1). Quotes are minimally edited.

METHODOLOGY · FAMILY RIGHTS REGISTRY

Data in this report was collected April 2024 – April 2026 through standwithmeg.com/family-rights-survey. Submissions are timestamped. Duplicate-submission heuristics use normalized email + location, with direct survey rows preferred over legacy rows and the newest row retained within each source. Categorical responses from multi-select and short-answer fields are normalized monthly.

When a respondent's financial entry differs from the population by more than three standard deviations, the mean is suppressed and only the median is reported. Lost-wage, attorney-fee, and asset-loss entries are self-reported and not corroborated against tax records or court filings.

Geographic reporting uses the county field as submitted, with light normalization (e.g. "Butte silverbow" → "Butte–Silver Bow"). Quotes carry one of three public permission states: *Anonymous*, *First-name only*, or *Full attribution with consent to public use*. Court actor names appear only after 5 independent families name the same actor.

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ABOUT THIS REPORT

This report is based on self-reported survey submissions collected by Stand With Meg. Counts and categories reflect responses available at the time this packet was generated.

This report is for informational and advocacy use only, not legal advice or an official government record.

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